

had a problem with their PC again, they found that the person had taken off to another country. "He asked a friend of his to service the computer if we had a problem and the friend did help us, but it was a favour and we'd have to pay him the next time he came over to take a look at the computer," adds Gerald.

So are dealers and computer assemblers out to get us? Well, not all of them. But you as the customer need to be careful. How many of us are really aware or take the trouble to find out about the warranties that we're entitled to or read the fine print while purchasing computer hardware?

Different warranties

Clear-cut warranties are offered on every consumer electronic product such as refrigerators, televisions or toasters that you buy. These warranties are offered directly by the manufacturer to the consumer and it's the manufacturer who honours the warranty in case the product stops functioning. So what's different about computer warranties? In the IT industry, computer hardware and software is routed through

Brands ahoy!

Warranties differ depending on whether you're buying a branded or an assembled computer. In the case of branded computers and peripherals such as those from Compaq, IBM or HP, the warranty issues involved are pretty straightforward. You buy the product through an authorised dealer and the manufacturer offers the warranty to the consumer through the dealer. The warranty period for branded desktops, peripherals, workstations or servers depends on different models and is clearly spelt out by the manufacturer. For example, the Compaq or IBM (India) Web sites have a warranty table with the duration of the warranty on different models and products. It explicitly states the warranty period for the parts, labour and onsite warranty (if offered) on a particular model.

What if I have an assembled PC?

In the case of assembled PCs, each of the system components such as motherboard, hard disk, floppy drive, CD-ROM drive, monitor, keyboard, mouse and so on, comes with a separate warranty from the respective manufacturer. The warranty period differs depending on the component. Reputed motherboard brands such as Intel or Asus and hard disks from Samsung carry a three-year warranty. But when you buy a computer from an assembler, you generally get a one year onsite warranty on the entire assembled system which states that components will be replaced should they fail to work within the warranty period.

While dealers generally offer a one-year warranty, there are some assemblers who will offer warranties of more than a year on certain systems, for example Pentium III computers. This varies on a dealer to dealer basis, so be sure to ask about your warranty options while deciding to go in for a particular configuration.

So if a dealer gives you a one-year warranty, but your motherboard has a warranty period of three years, how can you ensure that you get the full benefit of the warranty on these components even after the one-year warranty the dealer gives you expires? What you need to do is ask your dealer about individual warranties and how you should follow up with the company service centre. Most reputed dealers, once the one-year warranty expires, will help you with this but won't follow up with the company on your behalf. You

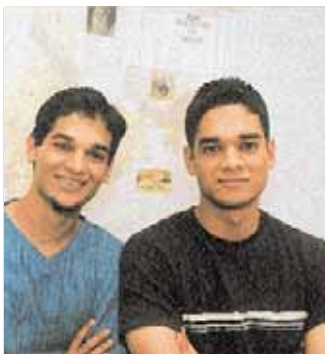
Understanding Computer Warranties

Before going into how computer hardware warranties work and what you as a consumer can and should do to safeguard your interests, let's first look at the different kinds of warranties offered on computers and peripherals.

A warranty refers to the performance of the product and states that the performance of the product will match what the company promises. Hence, if something goes wrong with the product during the warranty period, the warranty states the terms and conditions under which a specific part or the entire product itself will be replaced.

There are different kinds of warranties offered by computer hardware manufacturers. A replacement warranty promises you replacement of the component or the product within a stipulated period, while a repair or a service warranty states that your product or the component will be repaired but not replaced.

Onsite warranties are offered for certain products, which means that an engineer or a service provider will service the product or attend to your problem at wherever the product is located. In most cases the onsite warranty requires that the product be located within a reasonable distance of the service centre. In case you're located out of range then at the point of purchase an option of a carry-in warranty is usually offered. A carry-in warranty indicates that you need to bring in the product to a carry-in repair centre or dealer and arrange to pick up the system after it's repaired.



Gary and Gerald Misquitta

Computer users, Mumbai

"We paid a much higher price than what was quoted in the newspaper ads and insisted on a written warranty from the assembler, but were told we'd have to pay around Rs 4,000 more if we wanted a warranty"

distribution channels comprising resellers, dealers and retailers before reaching the customer. Hence, the warranty is offered by the dealer from whom you purchase the product and is supposed to be honoured by the dealer himself.

Computer dealers and assemblers normally keep a buffer stock of components, which they purchase for the express purpose of replacements. In some cases, they are required by manufacturers to keep a buffer stock. If you have any problems with the hardware you've purchased, it's the dealer who either replaces the hardware from their buffer stock or follows up with the manufacturer/authorised reseller on your behalf for replacement or service.

There's no clear-cut policy on warranties as different dealers and assemblers offer different types of warranties to their customers. Some even offer warranties of different duration.